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MY HINDUISM

Why am I a Hindu?

The obvious answer to this question is, of course, that it's because I was born one. Most people have little choice about the faith they grow up with: it was selected for them at birth, by the accident of geography and their parents' cultural moorings. The overwhelming majority of Hindus in the world were born Hindu. A small handful, inspired by marriage, migration or philosophical conviction, have adopted the faith, usually by a process of 'conversion' unknown to most Hindus. Unlike that small minority, I was never anything else: I was born a Hindu, grew up as one, and have considered myself one all my life.

But what does being a Hindu mean? Many of us began having to interrogate ourselves in the late 1980s, when the world media first began to speak and write of 'Hindu fundamentalism'. This was odd, because we knew of Hinduism as a religion without fundamentals: no founder or prophet, no organised church, no compulsory beliefs or rites of worship, no uniform conception of the 'good life', no single sacred book.

My Hinduism was a lived faith; it was a Hinduism of experience and upbringing, a Hinduism of observation and conversation, not one anchored in deep religious study (though of course the two are not mutually exclusive). I knew few mantras, just a few snatches of a couple of hymns and practically no Sanskrit: my knowledge of Hindu sacred texts and philosophies came entirely from reading them in English translation. (When I went to a temple, I prayed in an odd combination of English, Sanskrit and my 'mother tongue' Malayalam, instinctively convinced that an omniscient God would naturally be multilingual.)

As a student of history I had always been curious about ancient Indian traditions and beliefs, and I had amassed a rather decent collection of books on the subject of Hindu thought, including multiple translations of the Bhagavad Gita. I had also been a passionate follower of the thoughts and speeches of Swami Vivekananda (as will be apparent in what follows). I had read widely in English about my faith, absorbing the